GEC1044 Field report

Chinese Medicine : Theory and Practice (National University of Singapore)

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GEC1044: Chinese Medicine: Theory and Practice



Field Report

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1. Introduction

The field trip to Thong Chai Medical institution was an immersive and unique opportunity, where I could gain a more tangible sense of TCM beyond our usual online lectures and classroom-based tutorials. This visit allowed me to learn more about the medical institution and gain hands-on experience for techniques used in TCM. In this field trip report, I will be explaining my experience and personal reflections during this field trip in detail..

2. Introducing Thong Chai Medical Institution

During this field trip, I learnt more about Thong Chai Medical Institution through Dr. Grace, who is one of the TCM practitioners there. She explained its history, of how it was originally established as a free clinic with the ideals to treat all equally and to help without discrimination[1]. Over the years, the medical institution also played an integral role in educating more people about TCM, through scholarships, seminars, herb displays and even a TCM library[2] (Figure 1). Today, the medical institution provides various TCM services, such as free medical consultations and herbal medication.

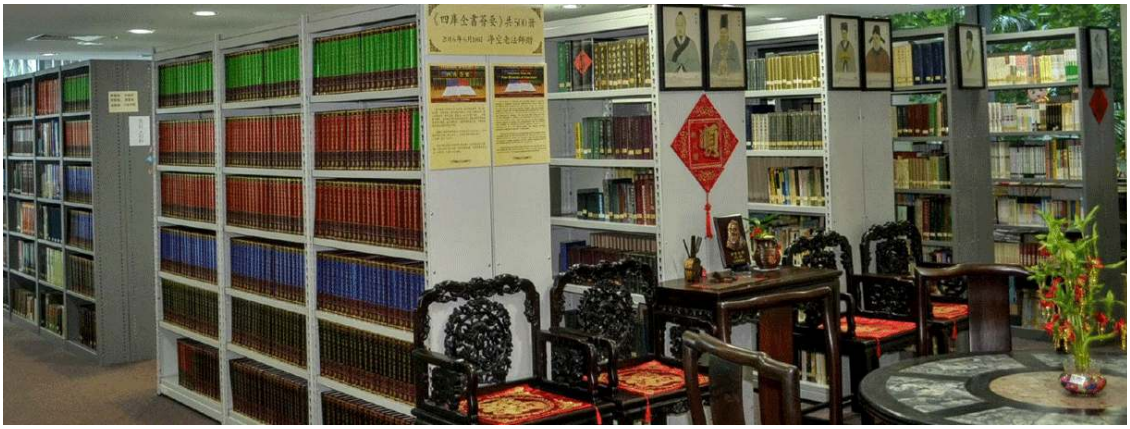


Figure 1: The current TCM library at Thong Chai Building[3].

Seeing the humble and nondescript exterior of the current Thong Chai Building (Figure 2), I was surprised yet captivated as I learnt about the long and rich history that this medical institution had. It also made me more grateful that students, such as I, have the opportunity to visit this medical institution and learn more about TCM here.

[1] “Our History,” Singapore Thong Chai Medical Institution, accessed November 11, 2024, https://www.stcmi.org.sg/about-us/history/.
[2] “Our History,” Singapore Thong Chai Medical Institution
[3] “TCM Library,” Singapore Thong Chai Medical Institution, accessed November 11, 2024, https://www.stcmi.org.sg/facility/tcm-library/.

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Figure 2: My view as I walked up to Thong Chai Medical Institution[4]

3. Diagnosis methods

Afterwards, Dr. Grace proceeded to explain the various methods of diagnosis in TCM.

3.1 Tongue diagnosis

Dr. Grace taught us what characteristics to look out for on the tongue body and tongue coating, using explanations and diagrams (Figure 3).

Tongue Body:

1. Colour: red indicating excessive heat, pale indicating qi-deficiency, purple/dark indicating blood stasis or poor blood circulation.
2. Shape and Size: swollen with teeth marks indicating dampness, small or thin indicating qi-deficiency.

Tongue coating:

1. thick & white coating indicating dampness-cold
2. thick & yellow coating indicating dampness-heat
3. no coating indicating yin-deficiency

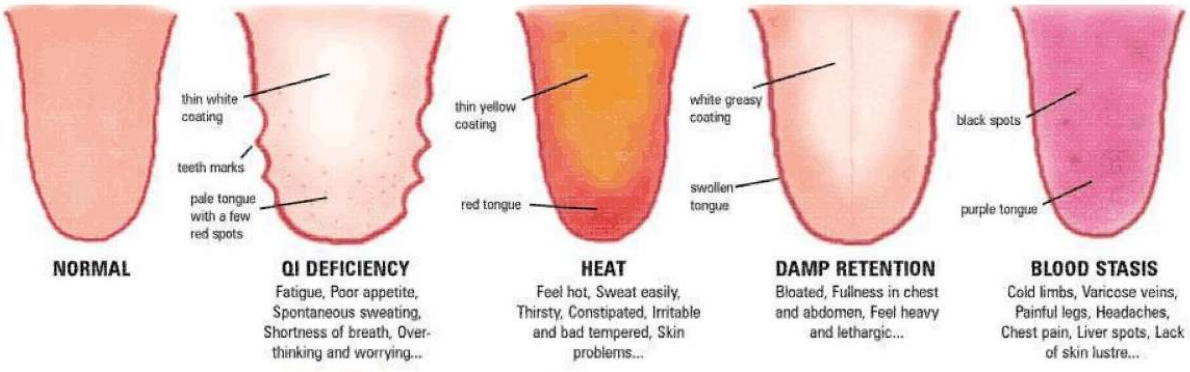


Figure 3: Diagram of different tongue types shown by Dr. Grace[5]

[4] "Test," Singapore Thong Chai Medical Institution, accessed November 11, 2024, https://www.stcmi.org.sg/about-us/test/.

[5] Katie Keville, "How to Diagnose a Tongue in Traditional Chinese Medicine," The Wellness Principle, August 22, 2022, https://www.tcmwellnessprinciple.com/blog/traditional-chinese-medicine-tongue-diagnosis.

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Tongue diagnosis was easier to discern and I had fun utilising the knowledge that I gained through observing the tongues of my family members and trying to identify the different characteristics. However, one challenge that I faced while observing the tongues of my friends (during the field trip) and family was that after someone drank or ate something, or scraped their tongue as part of their dental hygiene routine, it was nearly impossible to do a tongue diagnosis.

3.2 Pulse Taking

Next, Dr. Grace went in depth about pulse taking and diagnosis. She shared about the different characteristics of a pulse and the various indicators in each characteristic, which includes:

1. Depth
    a. *FuMai* - pulse felt strongly from the surface, indicating external invasion
    b. *ChenMai* - pulse only felt after pressing deeply, indicating a weak constitution
2. Speed
    a. *ShuoMai* - rapid pulse, indicating heat syndromes
    b. *HuanMai* - moderate pulse, indicating healthy pulse or syndromes of damp, insufficient Qi and Blood
    c. *JieMai* or *DaiMai* - pulse stopping at intermittent intervals, indicating heart problems, poor health, or trauma conditions
3. Strength
    a. *ShiMai* - Excess or Strong pulse, indicating excess syndrome or healthy
    b. *XiMai* - fine or thin pulse, indicating Qi and Blood deficiency or Yin Deficiency
4. Special characteristics
    a. *XianMai* - stringy and long pulse, indicating stress, anger, liver and gallbladder disease or abnormal circulation of Qi
    b. *HuaMai* - Slippery pulse, feels like a rolling bead, indicating fluid retention, excess heat, pregnant women or healthy

She also showed us the different pulse positions that corresponded to different meridian points (Figure 4) and the different factors that pulse can be influenced by.

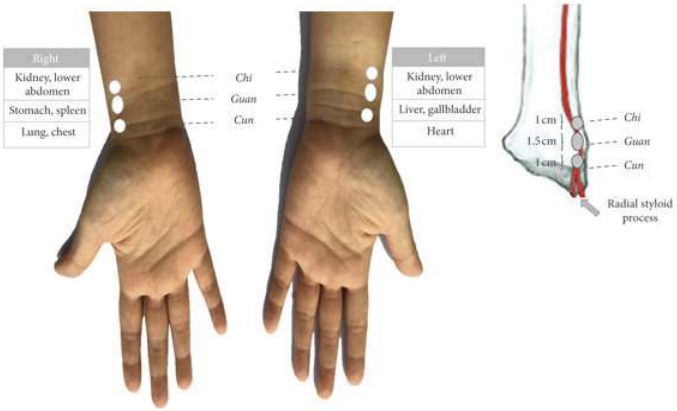


Figure 4: Similar diagram of different pulse positions showed by Dr. Grace[6]

[6] Hui-Ping Ng et al., "Acupuncture Differentially Affects the High-Frequency Spectral Energy in Radial Pulse Positions Depending on Type of Lower Back Pain," *Evidence-Based Complementary and Alternative Medicine* 2019 (November 21, 2019): 1–16, https://doi.org/10.1155/2019/4024501.

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For this diagnosis method, it was easy for me to find my pulse, but very difficult to identify whether my pulse was normal or had abnormality. Even after trying pulse taking on my family members, the only distinct one that I could feel was *Hua Mai* from my brother. This made me appreciate the dedication and expertise that TCM doctors have. It also brought to life Dr. Wayne's point (from Lecture 7 on TCM diagnostics) that only by feeling a thousand pulses can we truly learn to distinguish between a normal and abnormal pulse.

4. Herbs and Formulary

Next, Dr. Grace shared about how TCM utilises herbs of various properties to treat patients. She explained the primary sources of Chinese herbs (plants, animal parts, minerals) and the properties of herbs (four nature, five flavours, meridian affinity and function). Here were some of the herbs that were on display for us to observe:

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 7 黄芪 *HuangQi* (root of a Milkvetch plant)	Sweet, slightly warm	Spleen, Lung	Invigorating Qi, consolidation of exterior defence	Fatigue, lack of appetite, shortness of breath, sweating, loose stools
 8 当归 *DangGui* (female Ginseng)	Sweet, pungent, warm	Liver, Heart, Spleen	Tonify blood, stimulate blood circulation, regulate menstruation and relieve pain, moisten intestines	Dizziness, palpitations, irregular menstruation, injuries, constipation
 9 玫瑰花 *MeiGuiHua* (dried Rosa rugosa)	Sweet slightly bitter, warm	Liver, Spleen	Promote Qi circulation, relieve stress, harmonise blood, relieve pain	Abdominal pain, irregular menstruation, injuries

[7] "Premium Huang Qi (Astragalus Root) 75g 黄芪 (黑北芪)," Thye Shan Medical Hall, October 21, 2024, https://thyeshan.com/all-products/preciousherbs/premium-huang-qi-75/.
[8] "Angelica Sinensis Slices Dang Gui," Traditional Chinese Medicine Provider in Singapore | San Teck Soon, accessed November 11, 2024, https://www.santecksoon.com/angelica-sinensis-slices-dang-gui.html.
[9] "Pure Organic Rosa Rugosa," www.alibaba.com, accessed November 11, 2024, https://www.alibaba.com/product-detail/Pure-organic-rosa-rugosa-flower-france_1600576951169.html.

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 [10] 杜仲 *DuZhong* (bark from a Eucommia tree)	Sweet, Warm	Liver, Kidney	Nourish kidney and liver, strengthen bone, tocolysis	Back pain, knee pain, frequent urination, miscarriage
 [11] 薏苡仁 *YiYiRen* (pearl barley)	Sweet, neutral, cool	Spleen, Stomach, Lung	Strengthen the spleen, resolve dampness	Fluid retention, urinary dysfunction, diarrhoea (from spleen deficiency)
 [12] 蝉蜕 *ChanTui* (Cicada's Moult)	Sweet, cold	Lung, Liver	Disperse wind-heat, alleviate itching, improve visions, relieve muscle spasms	Common cold, skin rashes, eye discomfort, paediatric sleep disturbance, Tetanus

Each herb brought up distinct memories and interesting questions/thoughts:

1. 黄芪 and 当归: Both herbs smelled incredibly familiar to me, as these 2 herbs were used by my grandmother to cook nourishing soups for the family. This made me reflect on the impactful role that TCM remedies played in the lives of many, especially for those in the older generation.
2. 玫瑰花: I could immediately recognise 玫瑰花, recalling how I once bought tea bags with this herb as a gift for my mother. Although I may not have known of its health benefits then, she liked the flavour of the tea.
3. 薏苡仁: This was another herb I recognised, as I like the flavour of barley water and drink it whenever I feel "heaty". After learning its benefits, I wondered if any foods or drinks that I consume regularly had other TCM benefits.
4. 杜仲 and 蝉蜕: These were 2 herbs that I have never seen before. Both herbs have very interesting methods of harvesting, and did not have any distinct smell.

[10] "Sulfur-Free Eucommia Bark: Du Zhong," Bai Zi Gui, accessed November 11, 2024, https://www.baizigui.com/en/sulfur-free-herbs/sulfur-free-eucommia-bark--du-zhong.html.
[11] "Roasted Chinese Pearl Barley," Everyday Botanica - Roasted Chinese Pearl Barley - Eu Yan Sang Malaysia, accessed November 11, 2024, https://www.euyansang.com.my/en_MY/everyday-botanica-roasted-chinese-pearl-barley-955616020150.html.
[12] "Cryptotympana Pustulata-蝉蜕," Evergreen Herbs, March 18, 2019, https://www.egherb.com/product/cryptotympana-pustulata/.

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5. Acupuncture

After going through the various herbs displayed to us, Dr. Grace taught us about acupuncture, its uses and things to look out for during acupuncture. Acupuncture can be used for pain, stroke recovery, insomnia, migraines, anxiety, depression, sinus congestion and more. Meanwhile, things to look out for include bleeding or bruising, skin rashes, nausea or infection. Dr. Grace then showed us a few acupoints:

1. 百会 - on the head, for headache, dizziness, insomnia, tinnitus, dementia, stroke
2. 曲池 - outer elbow, for pain relief in the elbow and arm, heatiness, toothache, sore throat
3. 合谷 - skin between index finger and thumb, for heatiness, headache, toothache, eye infections, digestive issues
4. 足三里 - anterior aspect of the lower leg, for digestive issues, boost immunity
5. 太冲 - dorsum of the foot, for liver Qi stagnation (stress, irritability, menstrual irregularities)

I did not take the opportunity to try acupuncture as I was quite apprehensive of needles. However, I could observe my friend getting acupuncture at her 百会 point, and she shared that it was actually quite painless. Prof. Charles Wong also shared that acupuncture needles were much thinner than other needles used for injections, so acupuncture would hurt much less. Nonetheless, I was also glad that we can massage the acupoints as an alternative.

6. Cupping

Lastly, Dr. Grace taught us what cupping is, its uses, different methods of cupping and what to look out for during a cupping session. Cupping acts as a deep tissue massage that helps with pain, inflammation, blood flow, relaxation and well-being. There were 3 different methods of cupping: stationary cupping (cups are left on the body), flash cupping (cups are applied and removed quickly) and gliding cupping (cups are moved along the meridians). Dr. Grace also showed us a diagram explaining what different cupping colours indicated (Figure 5).



Figure 5: Indications of Different Cupping Colours[13]

[13] “What Do Your Cupping Colours Tell You?,” Thomson Medical, accessed November 11, 2024, https://www.thomsonmedical.com/blog/tcm/what-do-your-cupping-colours-tell-you.

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Next, Dr. Grace invited one of the students to participate in a cupping demonstration. This was the first time that I have seen cupping done in real life and I found it fascinating to watch how skillfully she applied each cup. The student that volunteered for the demonstration was quite healthy, as his skin after the cupping had a colouring that fit a balanced body type. Meanwhile, Prof. Charles Wong shared about another student's demonstration, where one spot of the student's skin was grey after the cupping, as it was placed over the area that he was injured at. This showed me the effectiveness of TCM techniques in revealing imbalances or injuries within the body.

7. Conclusion

This field trip to Thong Chai Medical Institution was an eye-opening journey into the world of Traditional Chinese Medicine. Trying different diagnosis methods, observing different herbs and seeing acupuncture and cupping up close, made TCM feel much more tangible. I also enjoyed discovering the history of Thong Chai Medical Institution and its commitment to accessible care, which gave me a new appreciation for TCM. This experience has left me curious and excited to learn more about how TCM can complement modern medicine and how to incorporate TCM into my daily life.

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